Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 8 (Academic + Wiki) — Advice & Conclusions

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Roadmap

1 Summary

2 Advice from Famous Writers and Scientists

3 Your feedback to us

What You Learned About

- Academic vs. encyclopedic writing (audience, voice, structure)
- How to write well: what is your message, and how to convince
- Evaluating sources and writing bibliographies
- Ethics: FAIR / CARE, openness, licences
- Feedback and peer review
- Practice both: (Academic) paper and (Wiki) article
- Transferable skills: argument, evaluation, revision, collaboration (on environmental topics)

Two paths to better writing

(Academic) Short paper (4–8 pp plus refs)

- Argument-driven, thesis-focused
- Synthesis and analysis
- Scholarly voice & citation norms
- Writing part of a larger process

(Wiki) Wikipedia article

- Neutral, verifiable, no original research
- Clear structure; accessibility
- Community standards, consensus

- One goal: **knowledge others can trust, find and build on**
- We compare genres to strengthen writing and judgment

Roadmap

1. Summary
2. Advice from Famous Writers and Scientists
   - Writers
   - Scientists
3. Your feedback to us

Plan for today

- 15 voices:
  - Writers: Stephen King, Ursula K. Le Guin, Octavia Butler, Haruki Murakami, Jorge Luis Borges, Chinua Achebe, Karel Čapek, Shonda Rhimes and Ta-Nehisi Coates
  - Scientists and researchers: Richard Hamming, Jane Goodall, Marie Curie, Timnit Gebru, Edsger W. Dijkstra, John Amos Comenius
- For each:
  - who they are → why listen to them
  - one or two pieces of advice, with sources
- Goal: learn a few good habits

Stephen King

- Who is he?
  - Prolific American novelist, especially horror, fantasy, and suspense
  - Author of *On Writing: A Memoir of the Craft* (King, 2000)
  - Known for disciplined daily writing and for demystifying the craft
- What is his advice?
  - **Read a lot, write a lot.**
    "If you want to be a writer, you must do two things above all others: read a lot and write a lot. There's no way around these two things that I'm aware of, no shortcut." (King, 2000, p 145)
    - Block time every day to read and to write, and do not give it away
    - Protect that block the way King protects his writing hours

Ursula K. Le Guin

- Who is she?
  - American writer of speculative fiction: *Earthsea*, *The Left Hand of Darkness*
  - Major voice on imagination, language, and power
  - Wrote the craft book *Steering the Craft* (Le Guin, 2015)
- What is her advice?
  - **Practice the craft deliberately.**
    In *Steering the Craft*, Le Guin treats writing as a set of skills (rhythm, syntax, point of view) that can be practised in focused exercises (Le Guin, 2015)
  - To try:
    - Pick one small skill to practice each day (clarity of argument, transitions, examples)
    - Write short exercises for that skill alone, separate from the main project

A Few Words to a Young Writer

Socrates said, "The misuse of language induces evil in the soul." He wasn't talking about grammar. To misuse language is to use it the way politicians and advertisers do, for profit, without taking responsibility for what the words mean. Language used as a means to get power or make money goes wrong: it lies. Language used as an end in itself, to sing a poem or tell a story, goes right, goes towards the truth.

A writer is a person who cares what words mean, what they say, how they say it. Writers know words are their way towards truth and freedom, and so they use them with care, with thought, with fear, with delight. By using words well they strengthen their souls. Story-tellers and poets spend their lives learning that skill and art of using words well. And their words make the souls of their readers stronger, brighter, deeper.

A Few Words to a Young Writer

Even here: that Socrates line is in no surviving Platonic text. The nearest is *Phaedo* 115e, on false words. A careful writer on the ethics of language, passing on a quotation she had not checked.

Octavia Butler

- Who is she?
  - African-American science fiction writer: *Kindred*, *Parable of the Sower*
  - First science-fiction author to receive a MacArthur “genius” grant
  - Essay “Furor Scribendi” gives blunt writing advice (Butler, 1995)
- What is her advice?
  - **Habit beats inspiration.**
    “First forget inspiration. Habit is more dependable. Habit will sustain you whether you’re inspired or not.” (Butler, 1995, p. 141)
    - Decide on a modest, daily minimum (e.g., 30 minutes of focused work)
    - Hit the minimum every day, even when you do not feel like it

Haruki Murakami

- Who is he?
  - Japanese novelist: *Norwegian Wood*, *Kafka on the Shore*, *A Wild Sheep Chase*
  - Long-distance runner; memoir *What I Talk About When I Talk About Running* links running and writing (Murakami, 2008)
- What is his advice?
  - “I think the first task for the aspiring novelist is to read tons of novels. Sorry to start with such a commonplace observation, but no training is more crucial.” (Murakami, 2022)
  - **Treat work like endurance training.**
    Murakami describes keeping a strict routine when drafting: early start, several hours of work, daily repetition, like marathon training (Murakami, 2008, 2022)
  - To try:
    - Choose a simple daily rhythm (when you start, when you stop) and keep it
    - Count distance covered, not perfection today

Jorge Luis Borges

- Who is he?
  - Argentine writer; short stories such as “The Library of Babel” and “The Garden of Forking Paths”
  - Explored libraries, labyrinths, and infinite texts

    “I had always imagined Paradise as a kind of library.” *(Borges, 1984)*

    From his lecture “Blindness”: he was made director of Argentina’s National Library in 1955, as his sight was failing. He says the same thing in verse in “Poema de los dones” (1960).
- What is his advice?

  All things have been given to us for a purpose, and an artist must feel this more intensely. All that happens to us, including our humiliations, our misfortunes, our embarrassments, all is given to us as raw material, as clay, so that we may shape our art. *(Borges & Alifano, 1984)*

Chinua Achebe

- Who is he?
  - Nigerian novelist and essayist; *Things Fall Apart*
  - Central figure in postcolonial African literature
  - Essay “The Truth of Fiction” on how stories convey truth (Achebe, 1990)
- What is his advice?
  - **Stories shape perspective**

    There is that great proverb — that until the lions have their own historians, the history of the hunt will always glorify the hunter.

    Achebe is quoting a proverb, not coining it (Achebe, 1994)

    I don’t lay down the law for anybody else. But I think writers are not only writers, they are also citizens. They are generally adults. My position is that serious and good art has always existed to help, to serve, humanity.

    “The Art of Fiction No. 139” (Achebe, 1994)

Karel Čapek

- Czech writer, playwright, journalist, and essayist; a central figure of 20th-century Czech literature
- Known for fiction such as *R.U.R. (Rossum's Universal Robots)* and *Válka s mloky (War with the Newts)*.
- Essay collection *Marsyas čili Na okraj literatury* (Marsyas, or On the Margin of Literature): language, journalism, style, and what writers owe their readers

Karel Čapek: advice on writing

- **A writer is someone who knows the language**

  Mezi všemi lidmi se vyznačuje nebo má vyznačovat spisovatel ne tím, že píše, nýbrž tím, že umí česky; avšak umět znamená pracovat, stále zkoušet, stále hledat a soustředit se; nikdy nebudeš hotov s mateřskou řečí.
  Marsyas čili Na okraj literatury (Čapek, 1931, pp 176–177)

  "A writer is — or should be — distinguished not by the fact that he writes, but by the fact that he knows his language; and to know it means to work, to keep trying, to keep searching, to concentrate; you will never be finished with your mother tongue."

  - Same lesson as King and Butler: the craft is work, and it never ends

Karel Čapek: clarity as responsibility

- **Clear language is a civic responsibility**

  Učiníte-li řeč zpěvnou a líbeznou, nebo dáte-li jí zvuk zvonu či děloviny, nebo učiníte-li ji jasnou a moudrou, pružnou, věcnou, lehkou, logickou nebo vzletnou, vnukli jste tyto ctnosti samotné duši národa; ale je-li vaše mluva těžká, zmatená, beztvará, obnošená a falešná, buďte zlořečeni …
  (Čapek, 1931, p 177)
  "If you make language melodious and graceful, or give it the sound of a bell or a cannon, or make it clear and wise, flexible, factual, light, logical or soaring, you have infused these virtues into the very soul of the nation; but if your speech is heavy, confused, shapeless, worn-out or false, be accursed…"

  - Muddled writing does harm beyond the page
  - Clear writing is a duty to the people who read it

Shonda Rhimes: writing under pressure

- American television writer, producer, and showrunner
- Creator of *Grey's Anatomy*, *Scandal*, *How to Get Away with Murder*
- Founder of the production company Shondaland
- Ran three weekly network shows at once (2014–2017), each with a script due every week
- Why listen: she has written to a deadline every week for twenty years

Shonda Rhimes: advice

- Write even when you don't feel like it
  "Dreams do not come true just because you dream them. It's hard work that makes things happen." *(Rhimes, 2014)*
  - Turn up and write, whatever the mood
- Say yes to discomfort
  "The very act of doing the thing that scared me undid the fear." (Rhimes, 2016)
  - If a task scares you, that is a sign it matters: do it anyway

Ta-Nehisi Coates: thinking through writing

- Who is he?
  - American writer, essayist, and journalist
  - Author of *Between the World and Me*
  - Essayist for *The Atlantic*; *Between the World and Me* won the 2015 National Book Award
- What is his advice?

  > *I was learning the craft of poetry, which really was an intensive version of what my mother had taught me all those years ago — the craft of writing as the art of thinking.* (Coates, 2015)

  - Writing is how you find out what you think
  - A draft is for finding out, so it is fine to start confused

Ta-Nehisi Coates: economy of truth

Poetry aims for an economy of truth — loose and useless words must be discarded, and I found that these loose and useless words were not separate from loose and useless thoughts. (Coates, 2015)

- Vague language hides weak thinking
- Cut the loose words and the loose thoughts go with them

Richard Hamming

- Who is he?
  - Mathematician and engineer; worked at Bell Labs
  - Known for Hamming codes and contributions to information theory
  - Famous for the talk *You and Your Research* (Hamming, 1986)
- What is his advice?
  - **Work on important problems.**
    "If you do not work on an important problem, it's unlikely you'll do important work."
    (Hamming, 1986)
  - To try:
    - Ask every morning: what are the most important problems I can work on today?
    - Reserve your best energy (not just leftover time) for them

Jane Goodall

- Who is she?
  - Primatologist and conservationist; studied the chimpanzees of Gombe from 1960
  - Decades of patient observation changed how primates are studied
  - Founder of the Jane Goodall Institute and the Roots & Shoots programme
- What is her advice?
  - “Only if we understand, can we care. Only if we care, we will help. Only if we help, we shall be saved.”

    (Goodall, 1999)
  - Watch for a long time before you theorise

    (Goodall, 1971, 1986)
  - “What you do makes a difference, and you have to decide what kind of difference you want to make.”

    widely reported; we could not trace it to a published text

Marie Curie

- Who is she?
  - Physicist and chemist; pioneer of radioactivity
  - First woman to win a Nobel Prize, and the only person to win in two scientific fields
- What is her advice?
  - Replace fear with understanding.
    “Nothing in life is to be feared; it is only to be understood.”
    - **But watch this quotation grow.** Nobody has traced the sentence to anything Curie wrote; the earliest print trace is a French medical article of 1951. The second sentence usually attached to it — *now is the time to understand more, so that we may fear less* — is Glenn Seaborg’s, written in 1968 (Seaborg, 1968).
    - If you cannot find the original, do not quote it

Timnit Gebru

- Who is she?
  - Computer scientist and AI ethics researcher
  - Co-author of “On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots” (Bender et al., 2021)
  - Founder of the Distributed AI Research Institute (DAIR)
- What is her advice?
  - Ask who pays the price.
    Bender, Gebru, McMillan-Major and Shmitchell argue that researchers should weigh the environmental and financial costs of training a model, curate datasets deliberately, and think through downstream harms (Bender et al., 2021) (a paraphrase, not a quotation)
  - Ethics is part of research quality
    Ask who benefits and who bears the cost before you build

Edsger W. Dijkstra

- Who is he?
  - Dutch computer scientist; pioneer of algorithms and structured programming
  - Author of influential essays and EWD memoranda
- What is his advice?
  - Clarity and correctness first.
    “Program testing can be used to show the presence of bugs, but never to show their absence.”
    Notes on Structured Programming (Dijkstra, 1972, §3)
  - Think before you write: for Dijkstra, programming is reasoning first and typing second

John Amos Comenius

- Who is he?
  - 17th-century Moravian (Czech) philosopher and educational reformer
  - Author of *Didactica Magna (The Great Didactic)*
- What is his advice?
  - Design learning so students do the work.
    "To seek and to find a method of instruction, by which teachers may teach less, but learners may learn more"
    Didactica Magna (Comenius, 1896, title page)
  - Education should be universal and systematic.
    Comenius' principle: *omnes, omnia, omnino* "everyone, everything, thoroughly"
    „Všechny všemu všestranně." (Comenius, 1657)
    - universal access to education (not just elites)
    - broad foundational knowledge, not narrow specialization
    - systematic, humane teaching methods that work

Putting it together

1. Work consistently:
   - King, Butler, Murakami, Rhimes: habit beats mood; pages accumulate
2. Choose problems that matter:
   - Hamming: importance; Gebru: responsibility; Goodall and Curie: patience and courage
3. Treat clarity as craft:
   - Le Guin, Dijkstra, Coates, Čapek: clarity comes through practice and revision
4. Remember people and consequences:
   - Achebe, Borges, Čapek, Comenius: language shapes stories, publics, and learners

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What did you learn, what can we learn?

- What was the most surprising thing in this class?
- What do you think is most likely wrong?
- What do you think is the coolest result?
- What do you think you're most likely to remember?
- How do you think this course will influence your subsequent writing/research/life?
- Is there anything we can do to improve this course?

What you have made

- A **Wikipedia article** that is public, and that people will read and go on editing after this course ends
- A **paper** of your own, with sources you found, read and cited
- Reviews you wrote for other people — and the revisions you made because of theirs
- The habit underneath all of it: **check the source, then write**

That is what sustainable knowledge looks like: work that others can find, trust, and build on.

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- **Claude Opus 5** (Anthropic, 2026) was used to check the slides: to resolve every DOI against Crossref, fetch every URL, and compare each quotation with its original. The prompt was of the form

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Verify every claim, DOI, URL and quotation against a real source. Where you cannot
verify something, say so rather than guessing --- never invent a reference.
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Each correction names the source it was checked against. Responsibility for what remains is mine.

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